

Teaching the Truth

Galatians 6:11-18

Small Group Bible Study Series

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① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Galatians 6:11-18

- 11** *See with what large letters I have written to you with my own hand!*
- 12** *As many as desire to make a good showing in the flesh, these would compel you to be circumcised, only that they may not suffer persecution for the cross of Christ.*
- 13** *For not even those who are circumcised keep the law, but they desire to have you circumcised that they may boast in your flesh.*
- 14** *But God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by whom the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world.*
- 15** *For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision nor uncircumcision avails anything, but a new creation.*
- 16** *And as many as walk according to this rule, peace and mercy be upon them, and upon the Israel of God.*
- 17** *From now on let no one trouble me, for I bear in my body the marks of the Lord Jesus.*
- 18** *Brethren, the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit. Amen.*

② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

"God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ."

Paul closes Galatians the way he wrote it — still in high gear, not slowing down, not softening anything. He has one final shot at these people, and how he says it matters as much as what he says: persuasively, precisely, plainly, positively, personally. That is not just Paul's method; it is a pattern for anyone who wants to present the truth of God's Word in a way that actually lands.

Underneath the Judaizers' push for circumcision was never really theology — it was motive: the approval of people, the avoidance of persecution, the appearance of perfection, and plain pride. Paul strips all of that away with one line: "God forbid that I should boast except in the cross." There is nothing else worth bragging about, because the cross is the only place a holy God and sinful people ever actually meet.

And that meeting produces something circumcision never could — not a religion, not an achievement to display, but a new creation. Old things passed away; all things became new. Paul carried the marks of that in his own body, scars from being stoned and beaten for preaching exactly this, and asked for nothing in return except to be left alone to keep bearing them.

Reflect

1. When you talk about your faith, is it more shaped by wanting approval, avoiding conflict, or looking good — or is it shaped by the cross?
2. Is there something you've quietly added to "faith alone in Christ alone" as if it were also necessary for salvation?
3. What would it look like this week to present the truth of the gospel persuasively and plainly, without softening it or dressing it up?

God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

Proposition: *Because nothing but the cross of Christ produces the new creation, the truth of the grace gospel must be presented persuasively, precisely, plainly, positively, and personally — without adding to it or subtracting from it.*

Introduction

We come to the final section of Galatians. Very often a final section gets short shrift — I remember a Bible college professor still teaching the book of Acts with two weeks left in the semester, five chapters of 1 Thessalonians and three of 2 Thessalonians never touched. But not today. We're looking at verses 11 through 18, Paul's last shot at these people. We want to know what he says — but more than that, how he says it, and why he says it the way he does, because that will show us how we are to present the truth of the Word of God. Of course, the subject all along has been grace — that we are saved by grace through faith, plus not one thing. You don't do something in order to receive salvation from Christ; He died on the cross that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life. That's it. Believe who He is, believe what He has done for you. That's salvation, and that's called the grace gospel — grace because it doesn't cost you a thing. The word "grace" has worked its way into our whole culture: we say grace before a meal, we're grateful for someone's kindness, we give a gratuity to a waitress, we're gracious to people, in England they call the king or queen "your grace," a little musical embellishment is called a grace note, and if you want to sing a hymn everybody in a crowd knows, of course you sing Amazing Grace. We're at the end of the epistle, and Paul is still in high gear — not slowing down a bit. He's going to rehearse, not say anything new, but he won't leave anything out either. So, what does Paul say, and how does he say it? That's what will show us how to present the truth of the Word.

I. We Must Present the Truth Persuasively – 6:11

Large Letters, Final Emphasis

"See with what large letters I have written to you with my own hand!"

First, in verse 11, we must present the truth persuasively — not, "oh, it doesn't really matter, here's something I want to say, if you want to hear it, it's okay." No — it's important, and I want you to know this. He says, "You see with what large letters I have written to you with my own hand." It seems that at this point Paul had been dictating this letter to an amanuensis, a secretary, and here he took the pen himself and said, let me finish this myself. This was his regular practice in every epistle — you find it in 1 Corinthians 16:21, Colossians 4:18, and even more forcefully in 2 Thessalonians 3:17: "The salutation of Paul with my own hand, which is a sign in every epistle; so I write." He signed every one. We don't have the originals — our earliest manuscripts go back to about the second century, but usually the fourth or fifth — so we don't have the actual place where Paul took over the pen, but he says he did, and we believe him.

So there are several ideas about what he means by "large letters." What do you mean, large letters? Well, it can't simply mean the letter itself is large — Galatians is six chapters, and that's not large compared to 1 Corinthians, Romans, even 2 Corinthians — so I don't think that's what he's saying. Some say he probably wrote large letters, large figures, because of his eyesight — remember, he said earlier that the Galatians would, if they could, have taken out their own eyes and given them to him, which may indicate he needed eyes — but I don't think that's what he's saying here either. Others say he wrote in capital letters while the secretary wrote in lowercase, because he did apparently have a problem with his eyes — maybe that's it. Or, maybe more to the point, he wrote in large letters to give one final emphasis to what he had been saying — in other words, if you knew computers, he probably hit Control-B, bold. That's what he's doing, writing very forcefully about what he's saying, so that it would give an impression they would not soon forget. So we must do the same thing — we must give our presentation persuasively. If you say to someone, "let me tell you about salvation" — if I ask you, could you pull out a tract like that? Yeah, you know what you can do. A little aside here: people say, "where's your church?" Oh, let me show you, right here — and I'm also giving them this, you know, the gospel. What's the gospel? If you pull the tract out and say to somebody, "if you want it, it's okay, don't worry about it" — no, don't do that. Pull that tract out and say, "here's something I want you to have. Please make sure that you have this. Make sure you read it. Do what it says. If I can help you, let me know — here, let me read it to you." That's persuasive. It's not just a thing I do so I can tell everybody I passed out so many tracts last week. No, not that — we do it persuasively.

II. We Must Present the Truth Precisely – 6:12-15

But we also must present it precisely, in verses 12 through 15.

A. The Unseen Motives of the Persecutors – 6:12-13

"As many as desire to make a good showing in the flesh, these would compel you to be circumcised, only that they may not suffer persecution for the cross of Christ. For not even those who are circumcised keep the law, but they desire to have you circumcised that they may boast in your flesh."

Paul looks behind the scenes here and tries to ascertain the motivation behind the Judaizers — today it would be the legalists. The Judaizers were going around saying it's okay to believe on Jesus, but you have to be circumcised according to the Law of Moses to really be saved. Paul says no — we have to be precise here. You believe on Jesus, you have eternal life. If anyone tries to add anything to that, they're wrong; that's a false gospel. So why were the Judaizers doing what they did? Paul points to their unseen motives.

1. The Approval of People – 6:12a. Today, these Judaizers would be legalists. People don't go around today saying, "oh, you have to be circumcised" — not today. But they do talk about things you have to do: you have to wear a coat and tie — no, I don't have my coat on — no, you have to do this, you can't smoke, drink, or chew, and you can't go with girls who do, that kind of thing. That's the same idea as the Judaizers, just wearing a different face. Talk with one of them for a while and you'll find out they're proud — more proud of what they do than of what Christ did. Oh yeah, we do this and this and this, and we're the special people. What did Christ do? Oh, He died on the cross. What about that? No, it's not that. So these people were the legalists of their day. Why do they do this? Paul says, in verse 12a, "as many as desire to make a good

showing in the flesh" — they're making a good showing in the flesh. Salvation does not depend on any work of the flesh. Oh yeah, Jesus saved me, but then we have to do this and this — look what I did, I do all that — no, that's a work of the flesh. The Judaizers wanted to show off their ability to get the Gentiles circumcised. Remember, we did a series on Acts — Acts 15:1 says this: "certain men came down from Judea and taught the brethren at Antioch, unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you cannot be saved." Now, that issue was settled soon after by the Jerusalem Council in A.D. 49, and there were those in Jerusalem who didn't accept that, and they went around telling churches, wherever Paul went, following him around, saying, "what he did was okay, it's okay to believe on Jesus, but now you've got to do this" — and that's where a lot of people are today. They wanted the approval of the people back in Jerusalem — they would write back, or go back, or send word back: "I even got some more people circumcised, all these Gentiles are getting circumcised, isn't that wonderful?" And so they wanted to get the approval of the leaders in Jerusalem.

2. The Avoidance of Persecution – 6:12b. Second, do you realize Paul was persecuted precisely because he preached the grace gospel? That's all he did — he went around telling people how to be saved, how to receive eternal life, and they persecuted him for it. Remember Lystra — they dragged him out of the city and left him for dead; Luke suggests he actually did die. That's the kind of thing that happened to Paul for preaching the grace gospel, and these Judaizers wanted to avoid that kind of persecution. Verse 12b: "these would compel you to be circumcised, only that they may not suffer persecution for the cross of Christ." When works come in, the cross goes out — you cannot have works and the cross at the same time. One writer says that when you add works to grace, it marginalizes the cross — no, that's not quite it, the cross goes out entirely; you cannot have works and the cross at the same place. If you want to put grace and works together, then neither of them is either one. Works are not grace, and grace is not works — that's Romans 11:6: "if by grace, then it is no longer of works; otherwise grace is no longer grace. But if it is of works, it is no longer grace; otherwise work is no longer work." All he's saying is you can't put the two things together. Considering all the persecution Paul had endured, this might have been quite a motivation for the Judaizers — "we don't want that, we won't preach that grace gospel, we'll add some things to it" — so they avoided persecution by not preaching the grace gospel. One writer quotes Martin Luther as saying, "we are saved by faith alone, but we are not saved by faith that is alone" — though I'm not sure Luther actually said it. What was meant by that is: we're saved by faith alone, but that faith will not be alone, it will also work. That's backloading the gospel — putting the works in after the fact, rather than frontloading the gospel by putting the works in front, before salvation. Either way, if you tell people they must believe in Jesus for salvation and then add good works later, you are saying there is some good already in them — that Jesus did what He did on the cross, but they still have something in themselves, some ability to add to what Christ did. But Ephesians 2 says you were dead in trespasses and sins — you can't do anything if you're dead; all you do is accept what Jesus gives you, and then you're saved. So when we preach that false, backloaded gospel, we avoid the persecution of those who look down their noses at the gospel of the grace of God — the gospel that Jesus secured for us on the cross, by Himself.

3. The Appearance of Perfection – 6:13a. Third, verse 13a: "for not even those who are circumcised keep the law." They go around insisting you must keep the law and be circumcised, yet they don't even keep the law themselves — only its outward parts. Only one Person who ever lived kept the entire law, and you're not going to be the second. If you keep part of the law

and not all of it, you haven't kept any of it — James 2:10 says whoever keeps the whole law and yet stumbles at one point is guilty of breaking all of it. So they kept the outward parts and appeared to others as law-keepers — Jesus called that kind of person a hypocrite — but it was all an outward show.

4. The Attitude of Pride – 6:13b. Fourth, verse 13b: "but they desire to have you circumcised that they may boast in your flesh." They'll say, well, we beat Paul today, we got some more, we got this many people circumcised — look what we did. Proud. Look what I did. You know, we have to keep that in mind too with evangelism — you see it on TV a lot: "we went to India, do you know what, more people have been saved in India than there are people in India." I haven't kept a real record of it, but everybody goes there — a million people saved in India, somebody else comes up, two million people — you know, the first liar has a disadvantage. Oh, two million. And they keep counting millions and millions of people, and what are they doing? They're getting numbers. You have to be careful of that, because that is pride — be careful how you give the gospel out, don't just get people to say "oh yeah, yes, yes, yes, everybody raise your hand." You have to watch this with kids — I worked with kids quite a bit when I was in college. You say, "who wants to receive Jesus, raise your hand" — every hand goes up. Then the next time you say, "everybody who wants now to believe in Jesus, raise your hand" — every hand goes up again. They want to please the teacher. You have to watch it — people want to please, people want to get rid of you sometimes, "oh yeah, okay, whatever." We have to be careful about this — don't let pride get in there and keep score on your gospel gun so you know how many you had, and brag about it.

B. The Upper Motives of Paul – 6:14-15

"But God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by whom the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world. For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision nor uncircumcision avails anything, but a new creation."

1. He Was Motivated by the Cross – 6:14. Against those four unseen, ugly motives, Paul now sets his own upper motives. "God forbid that I should boast except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ." Boast — brag about something. If you want to brag about something, Paul says, brag about the cross. There was nothing else there to brag about — Paul had nothing, he was nothing, he would be nothing, except as Jesus Christ did something through him. The Judaizers saw the cross as a symbol of shame; in other religions, it is an offense, even today. Have you been following the story about the Muslims at a Catholic college who asked for a room where they could pray four or five times a day, and were given one — but it had a permanent cross in it, and they complained about that and sued over it? Why? Because to them it's a curse, an offense — the same way it's an offense to a lot of people today: "why are you wearing a cross, why do you have that bumper sticker, that sign on the side of your car, aren't you afraid to offend somebody?" If I offend somebody, I hope they tell me — then I can give them the gospel. All I'm saying is, it is an offense, and the cross is an offense. But if you add works to it, you have negated the cross. So the cross was Paul's message. He says it in 1 Corinthians 1:22-24 — "Jews request a sign, and Greeks seek after wisdom; but we preach Christ crucified, to the Jews a stumbling block and to the Greeks foolishness, but to those who are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God and the wisdom of God." The Greeks called it foolish — but what's foolish about a gospel where you don't have to do anything? People love having a list of things to do; give them ten things to check off and they'll gladly do it. But the old idea holds

true everywhere else — there's no free lunch, you don't get something for nothing — except right here, where you get something for nothing, for not one thing you have to pay, because the work has already been done by Jesus. And that's exactly what offends people: it says you are completely dependent on God. I was talking to someone recently and told him Jesus did the work for him, and he said, "I'll do the work for myself." No, you won't — the work has already been done; you either accept it as free, or you don't get it at all. The cross is the only connection between a holy God and sinful man, a reminder of man's total dependence upon God's grace, with nothing else able to serve as a substitute for it or a supplement to it. The cross was more than a symbol to Paul — it represented the place where he met the Savior, and it also represented the means by which he would serve that Savior the rest of his life. The Judaizers knew nothing of that kind of dedication.

2. He Was Motivated by Christ – 6:15. Paul was also motivated by Christ. "For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision nor uncircumcision avails anything, but a new creation." Now, lest anyone should look down on a Jew for being circumcised, Paul points out that circumcision didn't get you in, but it won't keep you out either — it's okay if you're a Jew and you've been circumcised, no problem; in Christ there is neither circumcision nor uncircumcision. He says elsewhere in Galatians, neither Jew nor Gentile, bond nor free, male nor female — there is no status in salvation; the ground at the foot of the cross is level. Therefore, he says, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; old things have passed away, behold, all things have become new — that's 2 Corinthians 5:17. If you're in Christ, you're in that new creation; that's what "in Christ" means, we're in the new creation. Paul isn't talking about a religion, whether it's Jewish or pagan — there's no such thing here; we are not a religion. If someone asks you what religion you are, I hope you won't just say "Baptist" — not that I'm ashamed of being Baptist, but Baptist isn't a religion, it's a relationship between God and man. We don't need to change our name to Community Church or the House of All Nations or some other innocuous name that doesn't mean anything — we're not ashamed of who we are, but it still isn't a religion. A religion speaks of what man can do to bring God down to himself; a relationship is what God does to bring man up to Him. Did you ever hear that song the Gaithers sing? "He came down to my level when I couldn't get up to His. With a strong arm He lifted me up to show me what living is." That's it — He came down to our level to bring us up to His. That's what Jesus Christ did.

III. We Must Present the Truth Plainly – 6:16

A. This Is How We Are to Behave – 6:16a

"And as many as walk according to this rule,"

The "rule" here is the message of salvation by faith alone in Christ alone, by grace through faith plus not one thing. We must not add anything to it, and we must not subtract anything from it — lest we fall under the curse Paul pronounced at the very beginning of this epistle. If you don't remember where that is, just start reading from the beginning; you'll run right into it. It is a curse to preach anything other than the true gospel of the grace of God. That is how we are to behave — live according to the grace gospel.

B. This Is What We Can Believe – 6:16b

"peace and mercy be upon them, and upon the Israel of God."

But here is what we can believe. Peace and mercy be upon them — upon whom? Instead of a curse for the false gospel, Paul now says there is peace for the true gospel. We are accepted by God — never more, and never less, than the moment we first believed; we are always accepted by God on the same basis, that is, on what Jesus Christ has done, not on what we've done. If you try to do something yourself, you've negated what He's done. So the blessing is especially, he says, upon the Jewish believers — "upon the Israel of God." There are some who believe this "Israel of God" is the church — the church is the Israel of God — and some translations even render it "even upon the Israel of God," making Israel and the church the same thing; the NIV translates it that way. But Paul isn't just saying peace be upon those who live according to the grace gospel and stopping there — he adds "and upon the Israel of God," and I think that "and" introduces something new: the Jews who have believed are the Israel of God. Paul said in Romans 9 that there are Jews who are not Israel, because they haven't believed, and there are Jews who are Israel, because they have believed — that's what he's talking about here, the Israel of God, those Jews who have believed. The translation "even" is possible, but the context indicates the other translation, "and," is just as likely, for three reasons. First, the repetition of the preposition "upon" indicates that another group is in view — peace be upon those who walk this way, and upon the Israel of God, two different groups. Second, of the sixty-five occurrences of "Israel" in the New Testament, none of them equates Israel with the church — the church is never referred to by the name Israel, so it wouldn't be here either. And third, when Paul refers to two kinds of Israelites, he talks about Israelites who have believed and Israelites who have not believed — and those who have believed are the true Israel, the Israel of God.

IV. We Must Present the Truth Positively – 6:17

The Marks of Dedication

"From now on let no one trouble me, for I bear in my body the marks of the Lord Jesus."

These marks were not the "stigmata" some claim to bear in imitation of Christ's wounds — Paul means the actual scars of his suffering for the gospel, from being stoned and beaten with rods and worse. They are proof of his dedication to Christ and His gospel. His point, plainly: you think I'm not dedicated? Forget that — these marks tell you that I am. Leave me alone; go find something else to fill your pathetic lives with.

V. We Must Present the Truth Personally – 6:18

Grace to the End

"Brethren, the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit. Amen."

Paul's benediction matches his greeting. Back in verse 3 he opened with, "grace be to you." After that, things went downhill for a while — he called them foolish, downright idiotic; he called them bewitched, as if under a spell. But eventually he began addressing them as brethren — those who had not fallen for the Judaizers' heresy — and here, in this final verse, he calls them brothers once more. Grace to you, and with your spirit. Amen. That's the whole epistle in miniature: salvation is not by works, not by any Jewish works or any other works — no works at all, only by the grace of God. That is how we believe, how we are saved, how we receive the eternal life that lasts forever.

Conclusion

Paul's last word to the Galatians is his first word to them, said one more time: grace. He presented the truth persuasively, precisely, plainly, positively, and personally — refusing every motive that would trade the cross for approval, safety, appearance, or pride, and boasting in nothing else. That is still the pattern for teaching the truth: say what needs to be said, the way it needs to be said, without adding to the gospel or taking anything away from it.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.11	πηλικοίς γράμμασιν <i>how large letters</i>	G4080 / G1121 <i>pēlikois grammasin</i> Adj-DNP + N-DNP (Dat. Neut. Pl. + Dat. Neut. Pl.)	STR (pēlikos): how much, how great, in size or figuratively in dignity. THAY: denotes geometrical magnitude, or figuratively "how distinguished." Significance: appears only here and Hebrews 7:4 in the NT — Paul draws attention to the visible, physical size of his own handwriting as he takes the pen from his secretary for a final, emphatic word.
v.12	εὐπροσωπῆσαι <i>to make a good showing</i>	G2146 <i>euprosōpēsai</i> V-AAN (Aor. Inf. Act.)	STR: to be of good countenance, i.e. figuratively, to make a display. THAY: to make a fair show, to please, with reference to things of the flesh. Significance: a rare word, found nowhere else in the NT — coined almost for this moment, describing an outward, cosmetic religiosity aimed at impressing onlookers rather than pleasing God.
v.12	ἀναγκάζουσιν <i>compel</i>	G315 <i>anagkazousin</i> V-PIA-3P (Pres. Ind. Act. 3rd Pl.)	STR: to necessitate. THAY: to compel, constrain, drive to — whether by force and threats or by persuasion and entreaty. Significance: the Judaizers were not merely teaching circumcision as an option; they were pressuring Gentile believers into it as a perceived necessity for salvation, the very error Paul has spent five chapters refuting.
v.12	διώκονται <i>suffer persecution</i>	G1377 <i>diōkōntai</i> V-PSM/P-3P (Pres. Subj. Mid./Pass. 3rd Pl.)	STR: to pursue, by implication to persecute. THAY: to run after in order to seize; to harass, molest, persecute. Significance: the Judaizers' push for circumcision was, at bottom, a strategy of self-protection — trading the offense of the cross for the safety of a law-keeping message that would not draw hostile attention.
v.12-13	περιτέμνεσθαι / περιτεμνόμενοι <i>to be circumcised / being circumcised</i>	G4059 <i>peritemnesthai / peritemnomenoi</i>	STR: to cut around, i.e. circumcise. THAY: of the OT covenant rite; the middle/passive form means "to get oneself circumcised, to receive circumcision." Significance: Paul

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
		V-PPN / V-PPM/P-NMP (Pres. Inf. Mid./Pass. / Pres. Ptc. Mid./Pass. Nom. Masc. Pl.)	repeats the word across vv.12-13, hammering the same charge — those insisting on circumcision as necessary for salvation do not even keep the law they claim to be honoring by it.
v.13-14	καυχῆσονται / καυχᾶσθαι <i>they may boast / to boast</i>	G2744 <i>kauchēsōntai / kauchasthai</i> V-ASM-3P / V-PPM/P (Aor. Subj. Mid. 3rd Pl. / Pres. Inf. Mid./Pass.)	STR: to vaunt, in a good or bad sense. THAY: to glory, whether with reason or without — used with "in" (Gk. en) plus the object of one's boast. Significance: the same verb used twice in direct contrast — the Judaizers boast in the flesh of Gentile converts they have circumcised (v.13); Paul refuses to boast in anything but the cross (v.14).
v.14	ἐσταύρωται <i>has been crucified</i>	G4717 <i>estaurōtai</i> V-PIM/P-3S (Perf. Ind. Mid./Pass. 3rd Sg.)	STR: to impale on the cross; figuratively, to extinguish or subdue passion. THAY: originally "to stake, to fortify with driven stakes"; in the NT, to crucify. Significance: the perfect tense signals a completed action with continuing effect — the world's claim on Paul, and his on it, was decisively and permanently severed at the cross, not merely weakened.
v.15	καινὴ κτίσις <i>new creation</i>	G2537 / G2937 <i>kainē ktisis</i> Adj-NFS + N-NFS (Nom. Fem. Sg. + Nom. Fem. Sg.)	STR (ktisis): original formation, the act of creating or the thing created. THAY: the act of creating, or created things collectively — of a wholly new order of being. Significance: kainē stresses new in kind, not merely new in time (neos) — circumcision and uncircumcision are both, in Christ, superseded by an entirely new category of existence.
v.16	κανόνι <i>rule</i>	G2583 <i>kanoni</i> N-DMS (Dat. Masc. Sg.)	STR: a straight reed or rod; figuratively, a standard of faith and practice. THAY: originally a measuring rod or carpenter's line; figuratively, a fixed standard by which one lives, judges, or acts — the source of English "canon." Significance: "this rule" is the measuring standard of the entire epistle — salvation by grace through faith, plus nothing, minus nothing.

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.17	κόπους trouble	G2873 kopous N-AMP (Acc. Masc. Pl.)	STR: a cut; by analogy, toil that reduces strength, literally or figuratively; by implication, pains. THAY: intense labor united with trouble, toil, or the trouble one person causes another. Significance: Paul isn't merely asking to be left in peace — he is asking the Judaizers to stop causing him the specific, exhausting trouble of having to keep defending the true gospel against their interference.
v.17	στίγματα marks	G4742 stigmata N-ANP (Acc. Neut. Pl.)	STR: a mark incised or punched, for recognition of ownership; figuratively, a scar of service. THAY: a mark branded or pricked into the body — in the ancient world, how a slave or soldier bore his master's or commander's identifying mark. Significance: the only NT occurrence — Paul's scars from stoning and beatings function as a brand of ownership, proof of whose he is and whom he serves, requiring no other credential.
v.18	χάρις grace	G5485 charis N-NFS (Nom. Fem. Sg.)	STR: graciousness, of manner or act; especially the divine influence upon the heart and its reflection in the life. THAY: unmerited favor and kindness that turns souls toward Christ and strengthens them in faith. Significance: the last word of the argument matches the first (1:3) — Paul opens and closes the whole epistle on the same note, framing everything in between as a defense of grace alone.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why does Paul mention that he wrote "with large letters... with my own hand" (6:11)?	He took the pen from his secretary for a final, emphatic close — most likely to underscore, in a visibly forceful way, the seriousness of everything he had just written, leaving an impression they

Question	Answer
	would not soon forget.
What were the Judaizers' real, unseen motives for pushing circumcision (6:12-13)?	The approval of people in Jerusalem, the avoidance of persecution for preaching the offense of the cross, the appearance of law-keeping perfection they did not actually possess, and plain pride in the numbers they could report.
How does Paul answer those motives in verse 14?	By refusing to boast in anything except the cross of Christ, by which the world was crucified to him and he to the world — nothing else was worth bragging about.
Why does Paul say circumcision and uncircumcision "avail nothing" (6:15)?	Because what matters in Christ is not any external religious or ethnic status but whether a person is a new creation — a relationship God brings about, not a religious achievement man performs.
Why does Paul distinguish "them" from "the Israel of God" in his final blessing (6:16)?	Because the immediate context and the consistent NT usage of "Israel" point to two groups — those who walk by the rule of grace, and, among ethnic Israel, those Jews who have specifically believed in Christ — not an equation of the church with Israel.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul says we must present the truth "persuasively" — not casually, as if it hardly matters. Where might you be tempted to undersell the gospel when you share it?

Leader note: See Commentary I — the large-letters illustration and the gospel-tract example.

2. What are some modern equivalents of the Judaizers' motives — approval, avoiding conflict, appearing put-together, pride in numbers — that show up in how we do evangelism or ministry today?

Leader note: See Commentary II.A.1-4.

3. What does it look like practically to boast in nothing except the cross of Christ?

Leader note: See Commentary II.B.1.

4. How would you explain to someone that Christianity is "a relationship, not a religion" without it sounding like a cliché?

Leader note: See Commentary II.B.2 — the religion/relationship distinction and the new-creation truth.

5. What "marks" — costs, scars, evidences of dedication — has your own walk with Christ left on you, and how do they shape how you present the truth to others?

Leader note: See Commentary IV — Paul's marks of dedication.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
6:11	Persuasively	Paul takes the pen himself to give one final, forceful emphasis to his letter — a model for presenting truth with weight, not indifference.
6:12-15	Precisely	The Judaizers' unseen motives (approval, safety, appearance, pride) are exposed and answered by Paul's own motives: the cross and the new creation in Christ.
6:16	Plainly	Walking by the rule of grace brings peace and mercy — upon believers generally, and upon believing Israel specifically.
6:17-18	Positively & Personally	Paul's scars prove his dedication; his closing benediction of grace matches his opening greeting, framing the whole epistle.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

1. Say It Like It Matters

Scripture: *Galatians 6:11*

Drawn from Commentary I.

Paul took the pen himself to add one final, emphatic word. Presenting the gospel persuasively means treating it as what it is — the most important thing you could tell someone — rather than something to apologize for mentioning.

Reflection: *When you've shared the gospel or a gospel resource with someone, have you undersold it, as if it barely matters whether they read it?*

Practical Step: The next time you have the opportunity, hand over that truth the way Paul wrote his letter — plainly, warmly, and like it matters, because it does.

2. Check Your Own Unseen Motives

Scripture: *Galatians 6:12-13*

Drawn from Commentary II.A.

The Judaizers' real motives were approval, safety, appearance, and pride — never openly admitted, always dressed up as zeal for the law. The same motives can hide inside our own ministry and evangelism today.

Reflection: *Is there a place in your spiritual life or ministry where the real motive might be approval or appearance rather than faithfulness to Christ?*

Practical Step: Name that motive honestly before God this week, and ask Him to replace it with a desire to boast only in the cross.

3. Boast Only in the Cross

Scripture: *Galatians 6:14*

Drawn from Commentary II.B.1.

Paul had every reason most people would count as boast-worthy and set all of it aside for one thing: the cross of Christ, by which the world was crucified to him and he to the world.

Reflection: *What do you find yourself boasting in — even quietly, even to yourself — besides what Christ has done?*

Practical Step: This week, deliberately redirect one moment of pride in your own performance or reputation into gratitude for the cross instead.

4. Live as the New Creation You Are

Scripture: *Galatians 6:15*

Drawn from Commentary II.B.2 and FGR (Robert N. Wilkin, ed., Grace New Testament Commentary).

In Christ, external religious status means nothing — what matters is the new creation God has already made you. That is a relationship, not a religion, an identity to live from rather than a status to perform.

Reflection: *Are you relating to God as a religious performance to maintain, or as the new-creation relationship He has already given you?*

Practical Step: Write down one specific way your "new creation" identity in Christ should change a decision you're facing this week.

End of Study · Galatians 6:11-18